

Playtest Report — Mech Arena

Specialisation Project (WIU) · Designer: KJH · Level 1: City Arena · Session of 26 July 2026 · 10 testers

Post Test Summary

We ran one remote playtesting wave with ten testers on 26 July 2026, using the city-arena build: start menu, thirteen-step tutorial, then one-versus-one battles against the AI. Each tester played the full loop on their own PC and filled in the 8-question survey immediately after playing. The group covered the intended skill range — two testers with almost no fast-action background, six casual action players, and two experienced Gundam EXVS / Starward players.

The findings below combine the survey scale scores, the mechanics-usage checklist and the free-text answers. Frequency reflects how many testers hit a problem: High means most, Medium several, Low one or two. Findings 1–6 come from development testing and are marked confirmed or closed by this session; findings 7–10 are new discoveries from tester feedback.

Findings

Finding 1 — Shield parry stun reliability

Frequency: Low · Severity: Medium · Discovered by: KJH (dev testing) · Follow-up: KJH

Blocking enemy melee absorbs the hit, but the attacker stun (the parry punish) was inconsistent in early development testing. A dedicated fix round — deriving the attacker from the hitbox hierarchy, plus diagnostic logging — went in before this session.

Status after session: Largely resolved. All ten testers used the shield and seven of ten reported understanding and using the parry punish; no tester reported a failed parry. Downgraded to Medium and kept open only for monitoring.

Finding 2 — Knockdown and death still use placeholder animations

Frequency: High · Severity: Medium · Discovered by: KJH (dev testing) · Follow-up: KJH

The mech tips over stiffly instead of playing real knockdown, get-up and death animations. The fix is to import Mixamo clips and wire the HitDown / Recover / Die states.

Status after session: Confirmed. One tester called the knockdown moment “a bit iffy”, and six of ten understood the yellow knockdown bar — the mechanic reads, but the presentation needs the real clips.

Finding 3 — Strafe and backpedal play the forward-run animation

Frequency: High · Severity: Low · Discovered by: KJH (dev testing) · Follow-up: KJH

The 2D locomotion blend tree has the forward run in all four direction slots, so sideways and backward movement moonwalks. Movement and facing are correct; only the leg animation mismatches. Dropping strafe and backpedal clips into the existing slots fixes it.

Status after session: Not raised by any tester — stays on the backlog at Low severity.

Finding 4 — Camera readability at close range

Frequency: Medium · Severity: High · Discovered by: KJH (dev testing) + 3 testers · Follow-up: KJH

Originally logged as building occlusion, but the session broadened it: with the enemy circling at close range the camera orbits fast enough to disorient — “the camera spins too much”, “especially up close, the enemy circling you...”. One tester named the camera as the single thing they would change. The camera score averaged 3.7 but with lows of 2. An orbit-rate cap (300°/s) shipped mid-session; it needs tuning, plus a Cinemachine Deoccluder for buildings.

Status after session: Confirmed — the most-mentioned issue in the free text (three of ten testers). Raised to High severity; top priority for the next build.

Finding 5 — Charge shot discoverability outside the tutorial

Frequency: — • Severity: Low • Discovered by: KJH (dev testing) • Follow-up: KJH

The hold-one-second-and-release input is taught in the tutorial but might be forgotten in real matches.

Status after session: Closed — all ten testers reported understanding and using the charge shot.

Finding 6 — AI difficulty calibration

Frequency: — • Severity: Medium • Discovered by: KJH (dev testing) • Follow-up: KJH

The AI dodges and shields telegraphed attacks, punishes landings and manages boost; the development impression was “challenging” but uncalibrated.

Status after session: Closed for calibration — difficulty averaged 3.0 out of 5, with eight of ten testers answering exactly 3 (“just right”). One experienced tester noted enemy bullet tracking feels stronger than the player’s; that observation is folded into Finding 8.

Finding 7 — The final combo hit sometimes fails to connect

Frequency: Medium • Severity: High • Discovered by: Testers (2 of 10) • Follow-up: KJH

Two testers independently reported melee whiffing: “Sometimes my last hit combo don’t hit the enemy” and “Melee doesn’t seem to connect properly”. The finisher carries the big knockdown payoff, so a whiffed last hit costs the player their earned knockdown. Candidate causes: the hit-window timing on punch 4, the victim being pushed out of reach by earlier hits, or the micro-lunge stopping short. Reproduce with hit logging enabled, then tune the hit-window events or the finisher micro-lunge distance.

Finding 8 — Getting combo’ed feels inescapable; enemy tracking feels stronger than the player’s

Frequency: Medium • Severity: High • Discovered by: Testers (3 of 10) • Follow-up: KJH

“Getting full combo’ed by the enemy 3 times in a row”, “Can’t escape a combo after getting caught”, and “enemy bullet tracking seems a lot better [than mine]”. Read together: the defender has no answer once caught. The EXVS answers to port are boost-stepping breaking incoming shot tracking (designed but not yet implemented) and verifying the AI’s string length. Also confirm the AI’s shots use the same homing numbers as the player’s.

Finding 9 — No audio — the build has no sound at all

Frequency: High (all testers; one raised it) • Severity: Medium • Discovered by: Tester • Follow-up: KJH

“i need some sound cues.” The build shipped with zero sound effects: no hit confirms, no shots, no parry clang, no knockdown thud. Audio is also feedback — several other findings, like the whiffed finisher and parry noticing, become easier for players to read once hits and blocks are audible. The fix is a first audio pass covering hit, shot, charge, parry, knockdown and landing.

Finding 10 — Movement input feel: instant turn and missing double-tap buffering

Frequency: Low • Severity: Medium • Discovered by: Testers (2 of 10) • Follow-up: KJH

“A/D can try to not have instant turn, try to add a delay in-between” and “The A/D double tap combos don’t have buffering”. Strafe direction flips instantly with no turn smoothing, and a double-tap made during another action is dropped instead of buffered. Planned fix: small turn-smoothing on strafe reversal, and buffering the second tap for about 0.2 seconds. One tester also noted some tutorial terminology assumes EXVS knowledge — worth pairing with a wording pass.

Results of Questionnaire

Ten responses, collected on 26 July 2026 via Google Forms immediately after play. Experience split: two testers with almost no fast-action background, six casual players, two EXVS / Starward veterans.

Question (1-5 scale)	Mean	Answers at 1 / 2 / 3 / 4 / 5
Q2 Tutorial: prepared for the real fight?	3.8	0 / 0 / 3 / 6 / 1
Q3 Controls: how did the mech feel to control?	3.8	0 / 1 / 2 / 5 / 2
Q4 Combat: melee combos + shooting felt...	3.3	0 / 2 / 4 / 3 / 1
Q6 Camera & readability: could you follow the action?	3.7	0 / 1 / 3 / 4 / 2
Q7 Enemy difficulty (3 = just right)	3.0	0 / 1 / 8 / 1 / 0

Mechanic understood and actually used (Q5)	Testers	Adoption
Charge shot (hold right-click, release)	10 / 10	100%
Shield (Q) to block attacks	10 / 10	100%
Punishing the enemy after a blocked melee (parry stun)	7 / 10	70%
The yellow knockdown bar (fill it to floor the enemy)	6 / 10	60%
Rainbow step (boost-step combo cancel)	4 / 10	40%
None of these	0 / 10	0%

Free-text answers — most frustrating moment / one change

“Sometimes my last hit combo don’t hit the enemy, pls fix”

“i need some sound cues”

“A/D can try to not have instant turn, try to add a delay in-between...”

“Camera movement — especially up close, the enemy circling you... / The A/D double tap combos don’t have buffering... / Tutorial is fine but there are some terminologies that didn’t [land]... / Knockdown duration feels a bit ‘iffy’... If there was one thing I would change it is the camera. Everything else works.”

“getting full combo’ed by the enemy 3 times in a row...”

“the camera spins too much”

“Melee doesn’t seem to connect properly, enemy bullet tracking seems a lot better...”

“Can’t escape a combo after getting caught.”

“Nil” (two testers)

Some answers are cut short in the response export; quotes are shown as captured.

Overall Impression

The game reads as intended: an EXVS-style arena fighter. The core loop — boost management, melee strings, knockdown pressure — held up for all ten testers, and mechanic adoption was strong: every tester used the charge shot and the shield, seventy percent used the parry punish, and even the advanced rainbow step

reached forty percent. The tutorial did its job (3.8 mean preparedness with no score below 3), controls scored 3.8, and difficulty landed almost perfectly centred — a 3.0 mean with eight of ten answering “just right” — across a skill range from action-game novices to EXVS veterans. Both veteran testers scored the game highest overall, which suggests the underlying EXVS mechanics are the right skeleton.

The priorities for the next build, in order: first the close-range camera behaviour, the most-mentioned complaint and one tester’s “the one thing I would change”; second, melee reliability, since the whiffing finisher undermines the game’s central reward; third, defensive options when caught — implementing step-breaks-shot-tracking and checking AI string pressure, which together answer the “inescapable combo” cluster; and fourth, a first audio pass, which will amplify the readability of every other fix. Combat feel (3.3) should be re-measured after the second and fourth items land, since both target it directly. Overall: a solid first external test with no blocking bugs reported, and a focused, achievable fix list.